RESEARCH ARTICLE CLASS PROJECT

Lifespan is Effected by Sex and Marital Status

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Abstract

Purpose: This project describes lifespan patterns in cemetery records and examines variation by sex and marital status. [you can do military service of males or pre- and post- a particular year - default 1930]

Methods: Recorded available birth and death information from gravestones and classified selected characteristics using evidence visible on the stones and in burial arrangements. [Go into much greater detail in the methods section]

Results: [Summarize the principal patterns in the class data.]

Conclusions: [State what the observed patterns suggest and note limitations. Distinguish lifespan in this cemetery sample from population life expectancy.]

Keywords: cemetery records; lifespan; survivorship; marital status; historical demography

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Background

Cemetery records provide individual birth and death dates that can be used to describe lifespan among people represented in a burial ground. These records are a non-random sample: cemetery access, preservation of markers, migration, family burial practices, and the choice of graves to record may all affect which people appear in the dataset. The analyses below therefore describe the collected sample and should not be treated as direct estimates of lifespan for an entire town or historical population.

Hypotheses

3. **Military service and lifespan:** I hypothesize that male records marked as military service will show lower lifespan than records not marked for service because of the draft and exposure to chemicals.

Methods

Field site and sampling

- **Where did you go?** We went to the sunset hill cemetary in Valdosta, Georgia next to the VSU campus on Thursday October 8th. We focused on the front of the cemetary and marked names, birth and death dates, maritial status, and if they were in the military or not.
- **What part of the cemetery did you sample?** We sampled from the south western part of the cemetary. We collected data randomly from the left side of the gate.
- **How did you choose graves?** We collected data based on trying to have a variety of different results. We made sure to collect some that were married and in the military, as well as, getting roughly an equal amount of males and females.
- **How did you handle nearby graves and family plots?** We sampled randomly to collect data from a broad spectrum. We made sure to collect data of all sorts. We made sure to include some families and single headstones by themselves to ensure there was a variety in our data.

Recorded information and variable definitions

- **What information did you record from each marker?** We marked each name, gender, maritial status, birth/death date, and if they were in the military. We also included if there was information on their headstone about them being a higher ranking in the military.
- **How was lifespan calculated?** We did not collect data on headstones that did not have death dates. We subtracted the death date by the birth date to determine the age that each died.
- **How did you determine military service?** We determined military service of each person by looking for any obvious engraving on the headstones of rankings, wars served in, or military plaques. If there were any information on the headstone regarding a specific ranking we included that information as well (ex. seargants, commanders, etc).

Dataset and analysis

- **How many records were collected by you?** [n =50]
- **How many records were included in the final analysis?** [n = ; explain exclusions.]
- **Were records aggregated with the class dataset?** [Yes / no. If yes, describe how duplicates and conflicting entries were checked.]
- **What summaries or plots were produced?** [Describe group summaries and empirical survivorship curves, including how categories were defined.]
- **What are the limits of the sample?** [Discuss marker preservation, incomplete dates, cemetery selection, sampling strategy, and any other relevant limitations.]

Results

The summary table in Figure 1 shows substantial differences in recorded lifespan by sex in this sample. Males had a mean lifespan of 59.0 years (SD = 20.4; n = 3), compared with 29.7 years (SD = 7.1; n = 3) for females. The marital-status breakdown is more tentative because each subgroup contains only one or two records. Among males, the two married individuals had a mean lifespan of 70.5 years (SD = 6.4), while the one unmarried individual lived 36 years. Among females, the one married individual lived 36 years, compared with a mean of 26.5 years (SD = 6.4) for the two unmarried individuals. These small subgroup sizes make the values descriptive; they do not support broad conclusions about sex or marital status.

The sex-specific survivorship curves in show a different pattern: the plotted means are 61.1 years for males and 57.3 years for females. The male curve remains higher through much of the earlier and middle lifespan, while the female curve reaches the 50% survival point later. The curves are close and change relative position, so the figure suggests that the sex difference depends on which part of the lifespan distribution is considered. The median markers indicate where each group's observed curve reaches 50% surviving; they are distinct from the mean values shown in the legend.

Discussion

Sex and lifespan. Research on sex differences in longevity points to a combination of biological, behavioral, and social influences rather than a single explanation. Austad and Fischer review evidence on sex differences in lifespan and aging across species, including humans (Austad & Fischer, 2016). In this cemetery sample, the observed female and male curves [describe the pattern] and [support / do not support] the prediction that [state your hypothesis]. The result should be interpreted in the context of this cemetery's birth cohorts and sampling process; it is not by itself an estimate of a general sex difference in lifespan.

Marital status and social relationships. Marriage can correlate with social support, health behaviors, household resources, and social integration, but people's health can also influence whether they marry or remain married. A large meta-analysis found associations between unmarried status and mortality, with some associations differing by sex (Wang *et al.*, 2020); a broader meta-analysis linked social relationships with mortality risk (Holt-Lunstad *et al.*, 2010). In this dataset, the comparison of married and not-married

Lifespan by sex and military service

Sex	Military	n	Mean	SD	Median	Minimum	Maximum
f	n	342	71.1	21.9	76.0	0	105
m	n	340	61.9	23.6	66.0	0	114
m	y	70	63.8	20.0	67.5	21	96

Figure 1: Summary of lifespan of males by military status.

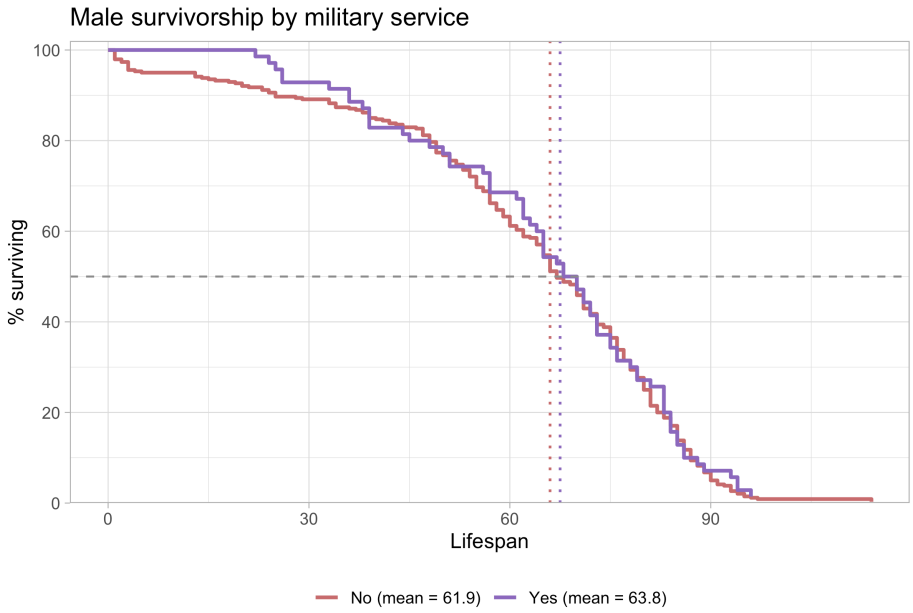


Figure 2: Survivorship curves of males by military service The y-axis shows the percentage of the cemetery sample surviving to each lifespan. Dotted vertical lines mark the median lifespan for each sex, where the curve reaches 50%.

records among [men / women / both] showed [describe results]. These cemetery records do not measure relationship quality, social contact, or the timing and duration of marriage, so marital status should be treated as an imperfect indicator rather than a direct measure of socialization or a cause of longevity.

Historical changes in lifespan and childhood survival. Life expectancy at birth is strongly affected by deaths in infancy and childhood, so a low historical average does not mean that every adult died young. Improvements in clean water and sanitation contributed substantially to mortality declines in the United States during the twentieth century, especially for infants and children (Cutler & Miller, 2005). The birth-period pattern in this sample [describe results] may be consistent with changing survival conditions, but birth year alone cannot identify which changes mattered. Vaccination, nutrition, medical care, living conditions, and the incomplete representation of people in cemetery records may also contribute to differences across cohorts.

Limitations and next steps: [Discuss sample size, missing or inferred data, cemetery representation, family clustering, survivorship bias, and what additional evidence would strengthen the analysis.]

References

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